

the other way round. A healthy stock price can at best help a promoter raise money, but he has to put the money to work and show consistent returns to the shareholders. Unless he is able to do that, his stock price will just flounder.

I got to meet some interesting market operators too. JC was the most notable of the lot, and I guess it had partly to do with his flamboyant ways. Anybody who met him once would not forget him easily. His showy ways put off many while amusing others. He had a fondness for expensive watches, and especially loved to tell people what they cost. His manner of speaking could be misinterpreted as offensive, and while that was not always intentional, he had ended up rubbing quite a few names the wrong way with his tactless remarks.

JC had been in the market since the late 1980s, but it was only in the last couple of years that he began to get noticed, for reasons right and wrong. He delighted in short-selling stocks, as though the task of chastening errant promoters had fallen to his lot. He would go long too on stocks, and had a decent-sized investment portfolio, but it was his bearish bets that got talked about and gave him the attention he relished. He won and lost big sums, and from what I gathered, it was his stubbornness that often got him into trouble. He claimed to be a value investor and not one of those operators who colluded with promoters to rig up stock prices. That claim was only partly true because I knew that he had cut deals with some of the dubious mid-cap and small-cap companies to boost their stock prices.

He called me one day and proposed that we meet up. I agreed. He invited me to his office, which I found a bit odd. Somebody else in my position might have taken offence. But I had heard enough about JC's idiosyncrasies to take umbrage at the suggestion. His calling me over to his office was his way of subtly asserting his seniority over me in the profession and telling me 'you come and see me'.

I drove down to his office in Andheri, curious to meet the man I had heard so much about. For a man rumoured to be worth a few hundred crore rupees, he had an office that was housed in a nondescript building that was modestly furnished and had barely half a dozen employees.

His cabin was spacious, though not outsized. His arc-shaped, glass-topped table held four trader workstations. Three were placed right in front of JC, while one stood to his right. There was a packet of Davidhoff beside one of the workstations. I glanced at his watch – sure enough, it was an